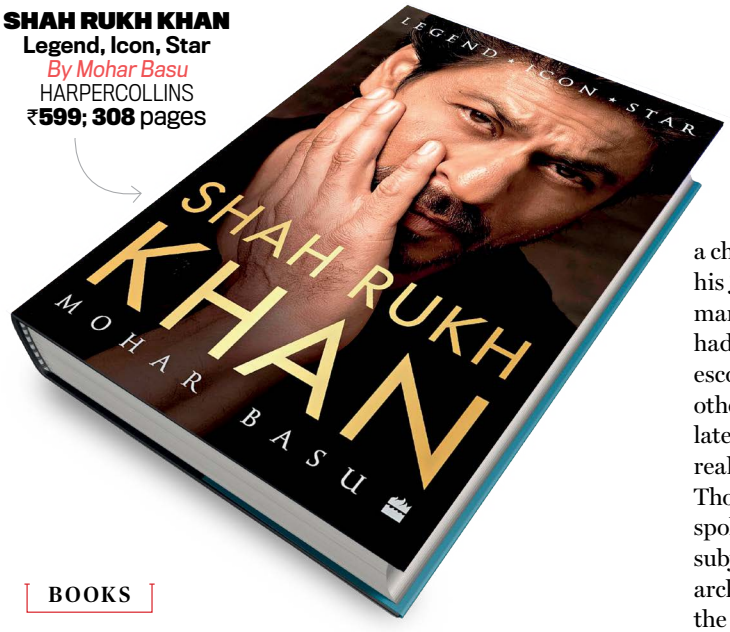
more memorable. In Hathi Ram, audiences got a hero who was plain and progressive, and simple and sorted as he tried to deal with messy situations.

For Panag, the trump card is Sudip Sharma's "genius" and his ability to see *Paatal Lok* for what it is: "That part of the world which exists but we don't want to acknowledge and choose to turn away from." Sharma thrived on building an entire new world all over again. "This [season] is more character-driven," he says. "It's also hopefully as rich and complex as the first one." If it does deliver eyeballs like Season 1, at least we know that Hathi Ram will use his crime-fighting skills in Rajasthan. ■

–Suhani Singh



SHAH RUKH KHAN
Legend, Icon, Star
By Mohar Basu
HARPERCOLLINS
₹**599**; **308** pages



BOOKS

A People's star

Mohar Basu's book on Shah Rukh Khan is a celebration of the actor's larger-than-life impact on his viewers and fans

An unnamed male model, insecure about his body, bought a gold shimmery shirt similar to the one Shah Rukh Khan wore in the song 'Tumse Milke Dil Ka' in *Main Hoon Na*. On days when he's feeling "out of sorts" with his body and the world at large, he wears the shirt and watches the film. Pinky Dube, a 40-something house-help from Patna, keeps hoping to discover traces of Raj from *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge* in her carpenter husband. She tells her daughter, "*Aadmi aisa khojna jo tumhari izzat karey* [find a man who respects you]."

When writing about a subject like Shah Rukh Khan who has been in the public eye for almost four decades, there is always the danger of regurgitating previously known information. Mohar Basu circumvents this by choosing to focus on his legions of fans and the oft-repeated sentence that "Shah Rukh is an emotion". Through his life and films, she explores what he's come to mean to fans around the world. The book is described as a "compendium of intimate stories, fan accounts and never-before-seen photographs" (by the late photographer Pradeep Bandekar), and it delivers.

The author traces the actor's life from a small *mohalla* in Delhi to becoming one of the most famous Indians ever. A large part of his journey like the C-Gang in St Columba's School, how he wooed his now wife Gauri or the inception of Dreamz Unlimited, his first production house with Juhi Chawla and Aziz Mirza, have been public knowledge for years. It's the smaller nuggets, though, like his trips to Pakistan as a child with his father or his *Jawan* co-star Priyamani recounting how he had his own bodyguards escort her and the film's other actresses after a late-night party, that really make the book. Though the author hasn't spoken to the film's subject, his voice through archival material forms the book's foundation.

Then, of course, there are fans talking about the impact Khan and his films have had on them. Like Zehan Motlekar, a techie who moved to rural Maharashtra after living in the US for a decade much like Khan's *Swades* character Mohan Bhargava. Or, Stacey in California who describes herself as a "52-year-old American woman who loves Bollywood and Shah Rukh Khan". All the Hindi she knows is from his films, she loves Indian sweets and has even gone on a Bollywood cruise! These do tend to get repetitive and maybe a tad simplistic—everyone wants a Raj/Rahul in their lives and a visit to Mannat is inspirational to those struggling to get by. While this might make it seem like a book that's aimed at fans, it's essential reading for those interested in Hindi films because Khan's legacy is more than just his work; it's also about the joy he has brought to so many for so long. And that's worth celebrating. ■

–Karishma Upadhyay